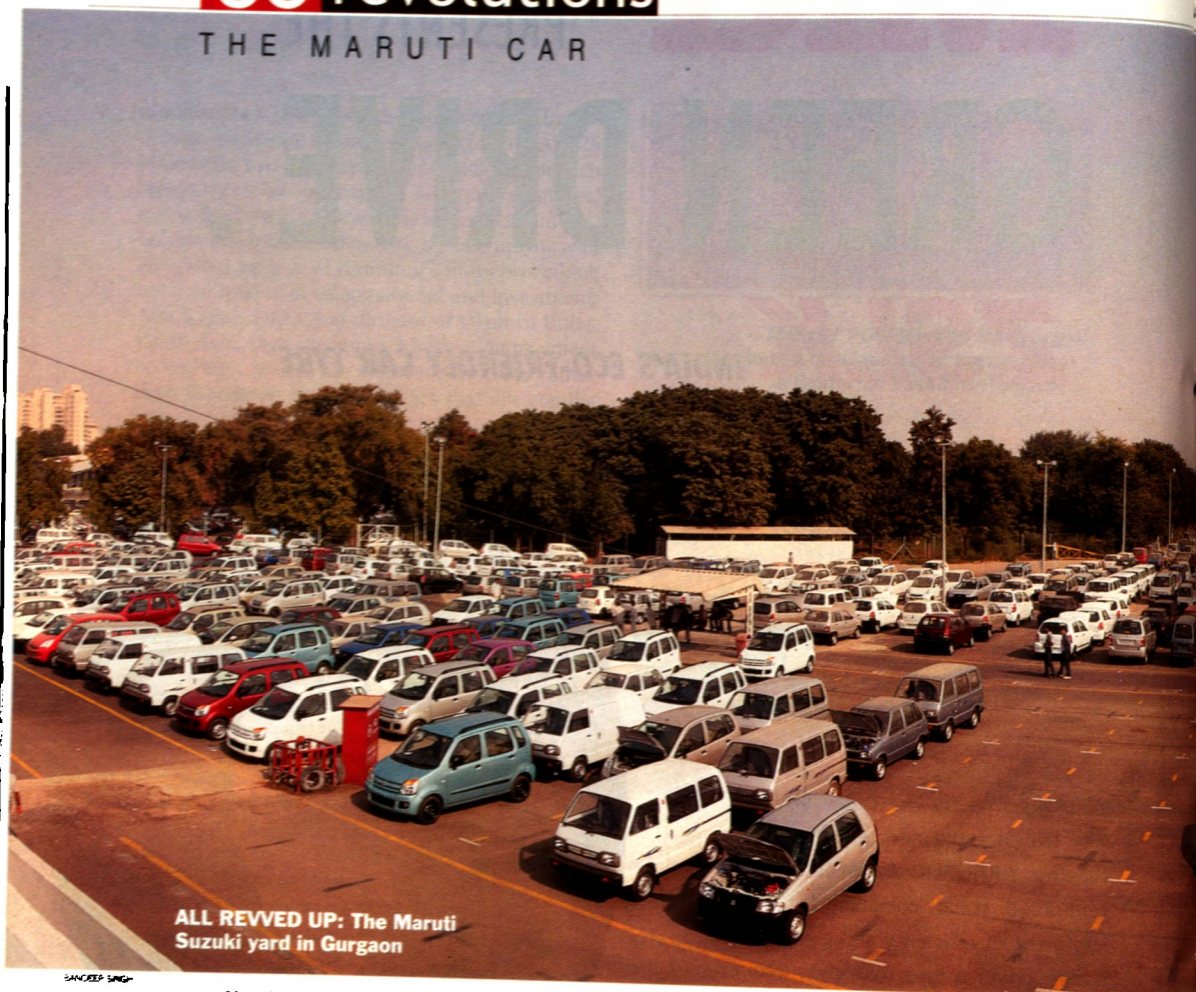


60 WINDS OF CHANGE revolutions

THE MARUTI CAR



ALL REVVED UP: The Maruti Suzuki yard in Gurgaon

■ By Nandini Vaish

On December 14, 1983, Harpal Singh waited with bated breath as the then prime minister Indira Gandhi handed him the keys to his new car, the Maruti 800. As he drove it, people stopped and stared. Owning a Maruti immediately increased Singh's standing in his locality—Delhi's Green Park area—and made him a quasi celebrity.

In a market dominated by three companies—Hindustan Motors (Ambassador), Premier Auto (Fiat) and Standard Motor Products (Standard)—which sold 30,000–40,000 cars annually for Rs 70,000, the

peppy, fuel efficient 800, costing Rs 52,000, was a runaway hit. The first year it sold 22,000 units and within four years it had crossed the one lakh mark. The car ushered in a new culture—a market for accessories emerged, women took to driving and the auto component industry got organised. Company officials would get innumerable requests for out-of-turn allotments as it became a popular dowry item.

Circa 2007, Maruti Suzuki India—a Rs 14,600 crore company that manufactures 6.75 lakh units a year—rolls out its 66,72,710th car. Besides Gurgaon, it has a plant in Manesar, Haryana, and exports to Indonesia, the Philippines, Algeria, Chile, Sudan, Morocco, Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Europe. In the early '80s, there were three car manufacturers and three models. Today 15 car manufacturers produce 3,625 cars daily and Maruti alone makes 11 models with over 100 variants. "Mera Sapna, Meri Maruti" still works for the countless two-wheeler owners who aspire to own their first car.

30%

of the cars sold in 1993 had ACs and were non-white in colour

80%

of the cars sold now have ACs and are non-white in colour